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BLOG

Website Structure: The Backbone of User Experience

We've all been there - lost in a labyrinth, clicking through a website, unable to find what we're looking for. That's the result of poor structure.



Edgar Frantsman / User Experience / Nov 21, 2024

Summary:

- A well-planned website structure is crucial for both user experience and SEO. It ensures users can quickly find what they need while helping search engines index your site properly.

- The four main types of website structures: Linear, Hierarchical, Webbed, and Database-Driven - each serve different project needs, from small sites to large-scale platforms.
- Key elements like navigation, breadcrumbs, URL structure, and interlinking are fundamental in creating a seamless user journey and improving search engine rankings.
- To keep your site optimized, it's important to regularly check for broken links, orphaned pages, and any gaps in your site's hierarchy.

What Is Website Structure?

Website structure refers to the way pages are organized and interlinked on a site, creating a clear and navigable framework for users. It's more than just the arrangement of pages - it's about how content within those pages interacts with each other, forming an intuitive ecosystem that not only enhances user experience but also boosts SEO.

A well-designed structure means users can easily navigate your site, and search engines can efficiently index your content, giving your web pages a better chance of ranking.

The Importance of Website Structure

In today's rapidly evolving digital landscape, a well-thought-out website structure is more crucial than ever. Offering a great service, product, or unique content is no longer enough; the key to success lies in making that content easily accessible, discoverable, and user-friendly. If your site isn't easy to navigate, you can be sure someone else's will be - and they'll capture your audience.

A solid website structure is the backbone of a seamless user experience, working in tandem with content and design to create intuitive, frictionless navigation. This, in turn, impacts your site's ranking in search results. Metrics like time on page, engagement, visit depth, and bounce rate - all of which are influenced by user flow - play a pivotal role in how search engines rank your site.

Whether you're building a simple blog or a complex e-commerce platform, a solid, logical structure is key to making sure your site serves its users - and your business - well.

Types of Website Structure

When it comes to website architecture, there are four primary types: linear, hierarchical, webbed, and database-driven. While they may go by different names across various sources, each structure has its strengths and weaknesses depending on the nature of your site. In the next section, we'll explore how to select the best website structure for your specific needs.

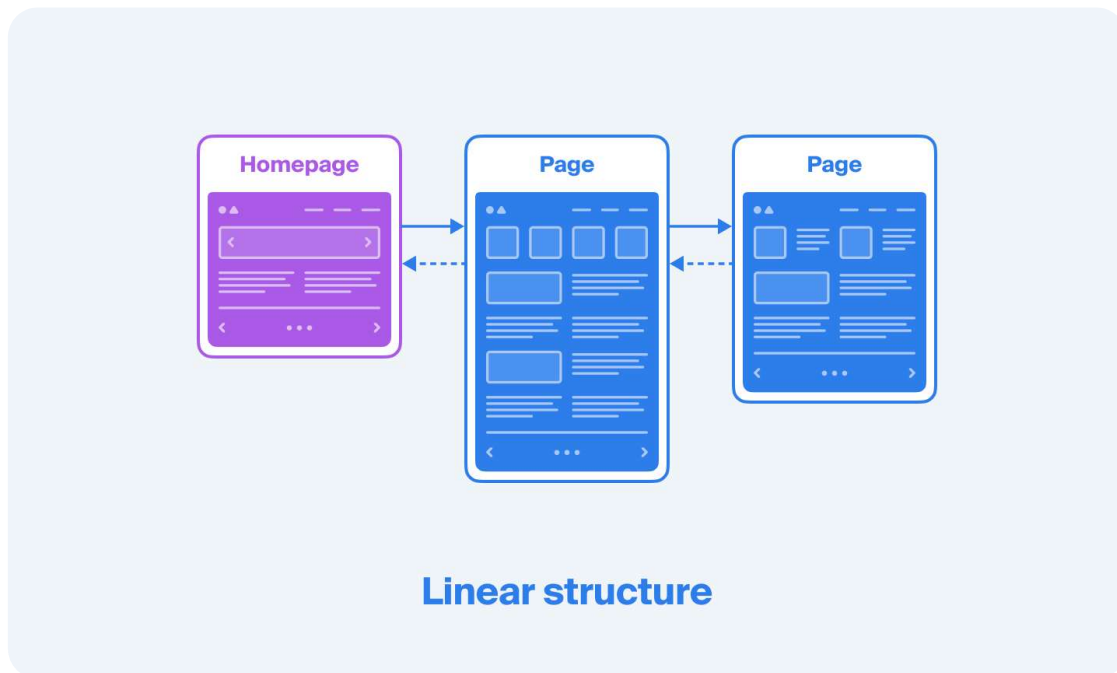
There are four distinctive website structures: **linear, hierarchical, webbed and database-driven**. Combination of several is hybrid.

Linear Website Structure (Sequential)

Best suited for smaller, simpler websites, the linear structure organizes pages in a straightforward sequence. Visitors start at the homepage and move through a series of pages, each linked to the next (and sometimes the previous), following a clear, step-by-step flow. This structure is perfect for guiding users toward a specific goal, whether that's reading through a set of information, completing a purchase, or submitting a form. Its

simplicity minimizes distractions, increasing the chances of completing the intended journey without veering off-course.

A prime example of this is the **Coursera** course page, where users are required to follow a linear progression, step by step, toward course completion. Or, a three-page promotional website where visitor enters a homepage, then is asked to complete an application, and then gets directed to a success-message page.



In linear website structure user journey is led in a specific sequence, page after page.

Hierarchical Website Structure (Tree)

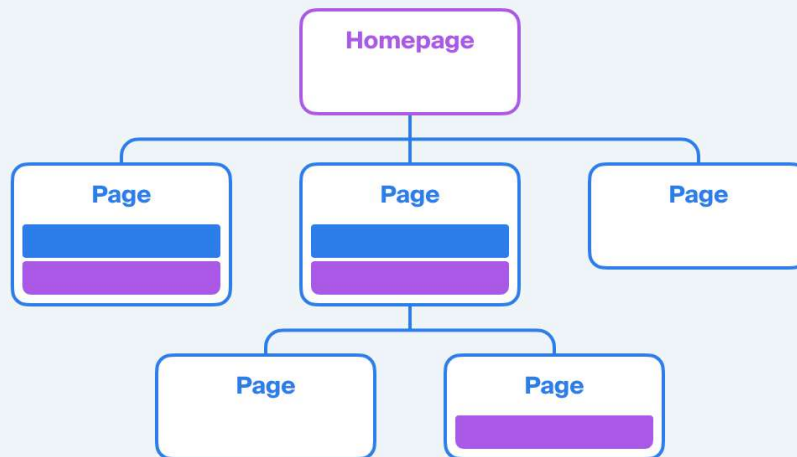
The most common website structure on the Internet, hierarchical structure is like a digital tree, where each page has one parent but can have multiple subpages. It's essentially a collection of linear structures, each branching out from a central node. This model supports multiple user flows, which makes it ideal for websites with various sections targeting different audiences or purposes. While this flexibility increases reach, it also adds complexity to site maintenance due to its size and structure.



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Apple's corporate website is a textbook example of this kind of structure, where the user can easily navigate between different sections such as products, services, and support. Other good examples are Microsoft, EA, and most of other corporate websites.



Hierarchical structure

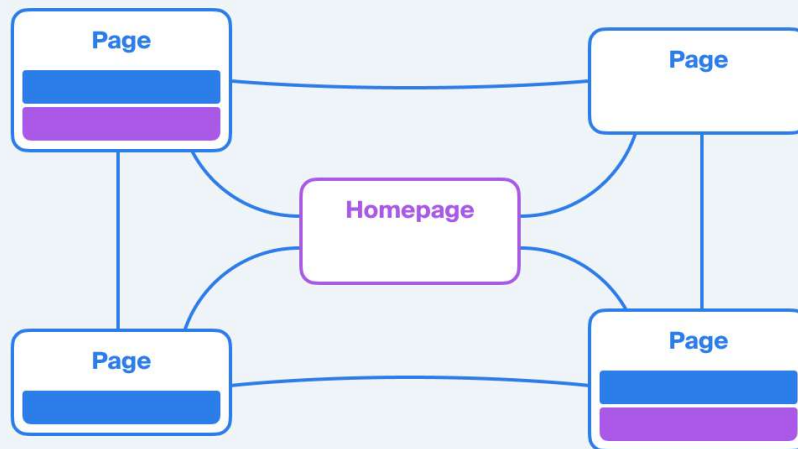
In hierarchical website structure each page can have multiple subpages, enabling several user journeys to reach different audiences.

Webbed Website Structure (Matrix)

In a webbed structure, pages are connected in a more fluid way, with most pages linking to one another. This creates a navigation experience that's far less linear and far more interconnected, allowing users to jump across sections freely. While this kind of structure offers maximum

flexibility and can cater to a wide range of user journeys, it also requires extensive internal linking and can become a maintenance headache.

Wikipedia exemplifies the webbed structure, where pages are densely interconnected, enabling easy movement between articles on a vast range of topics.



Webbed structure

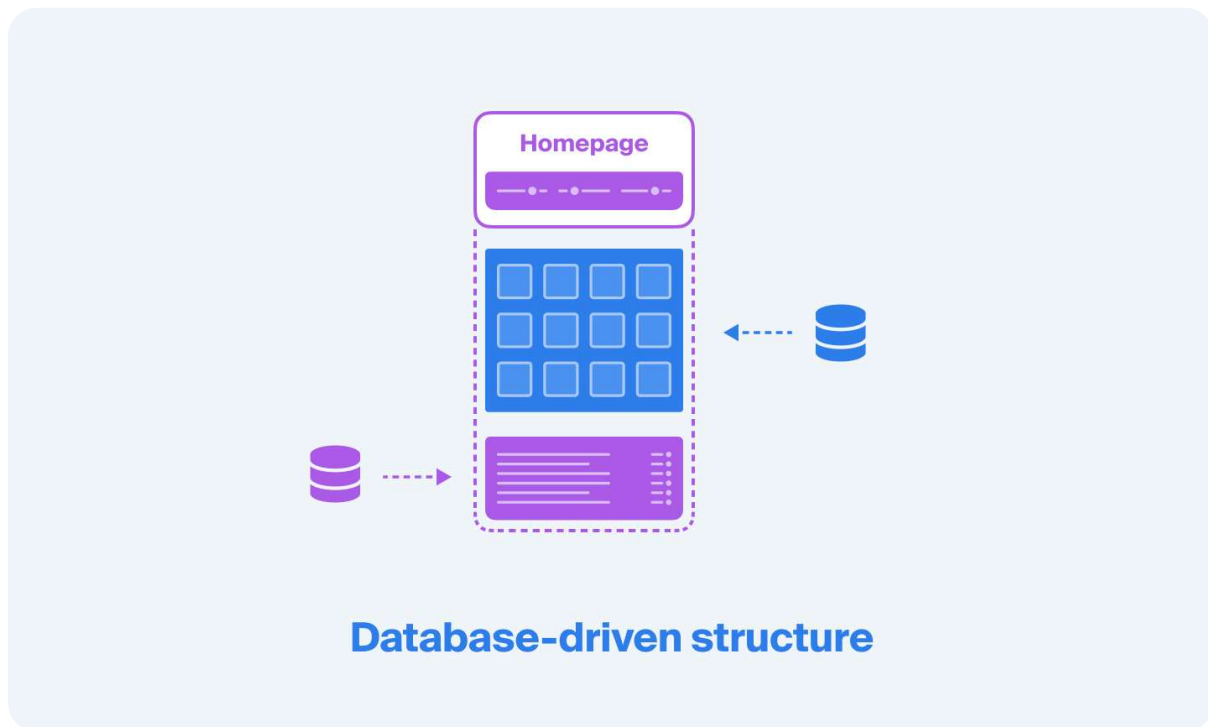
In webbed website structure all pages are linked together to maximise engagement and session time.

Database-Driven Website Structure

The database-driven structure is a bit of a game-changer. Unlike the other types, it's powered by dynamic content generation, where pages are built by pulling data from a centralized database. This allows for massive scalability, making it ideal for websites with a large volume of content, such as e-commerce platforms or listing services. The structure may look similar to the others, but behind the scenes, it's a bottom-up model where content is created by user actions or other external inputs.

Pinterest is a prime example, where every page is generated dynamically based on real-time data pulled from a massive database of

listings, reviews, and user-generated content.



In database-driven website structure information on page is generated dynamically.

Contents of Website Structure

Homepage

The homepage is the digital storefront of your site - the first impression visitors get when they land. As the primary entry point, it provides an overview of what your site offers, showcasing key content and serving as a launchpad for user journeys. A well-designed homepage sets the tone for the entire experience, guiding users toward the areas that matter most and encouraging further exploration. Its role in the user journey can't be overstated, as it shapes perceptions and directs engagement right from the get-go.

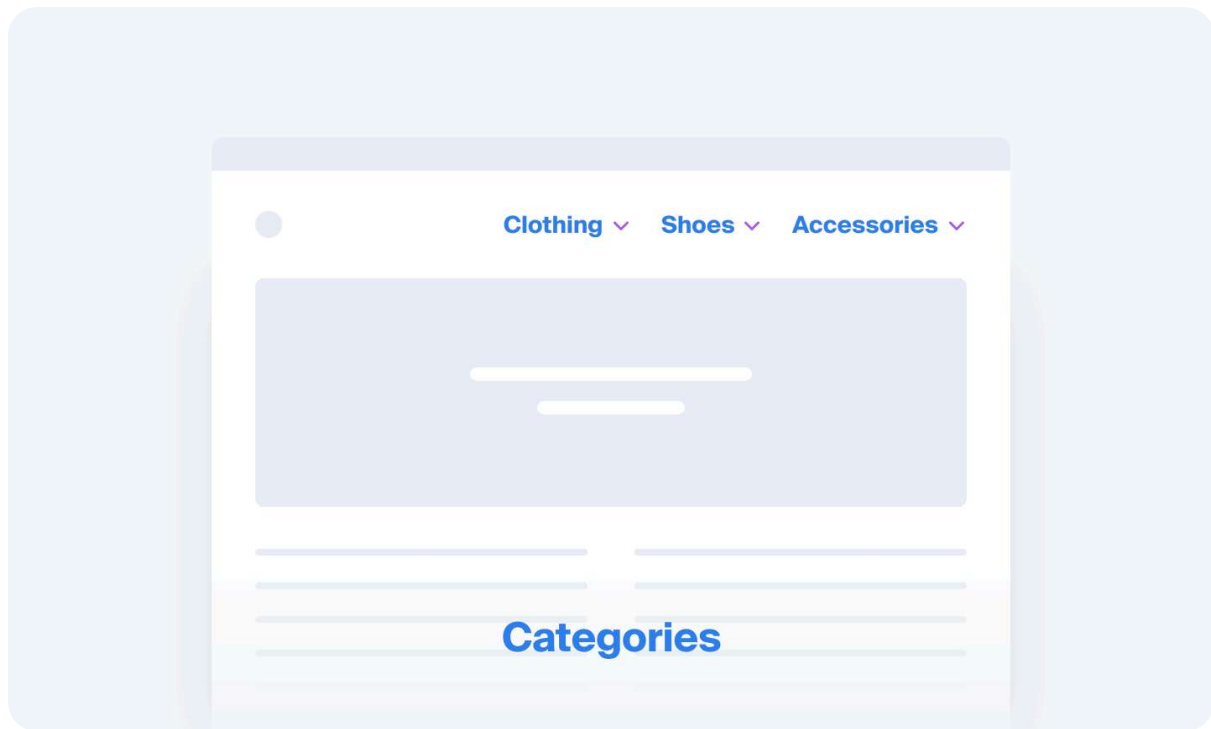
Navigation

Website navigation is the backbone of any website's usability, helping users find their way through your content with ease. Whether it's a top menu, side panel, or footer links, well-structured navigation is crucial for keeping the user experience frictionless. It allows visitors to effortlessly access key categories and content, minimizing frustration and boosting satisfaction.

Proper navigation has a strong impact on SEO by reinforcing the clarity of the site structure for both users and search engines.

Categories

Categories and subcategories are your website's organizational framework. Think of them as signposts that group content into logical sections, making it easier for users to find relevant information (just like a well-organized store layout). Categories play a pivotal role in user experience by providing clear paths to related content, while also helping search engines understand the structure and context of your site. A solid categorization system makes content more discoverable and helps search engines better index your pages.



Categories help users to find information quickly and reduce bounce rate.

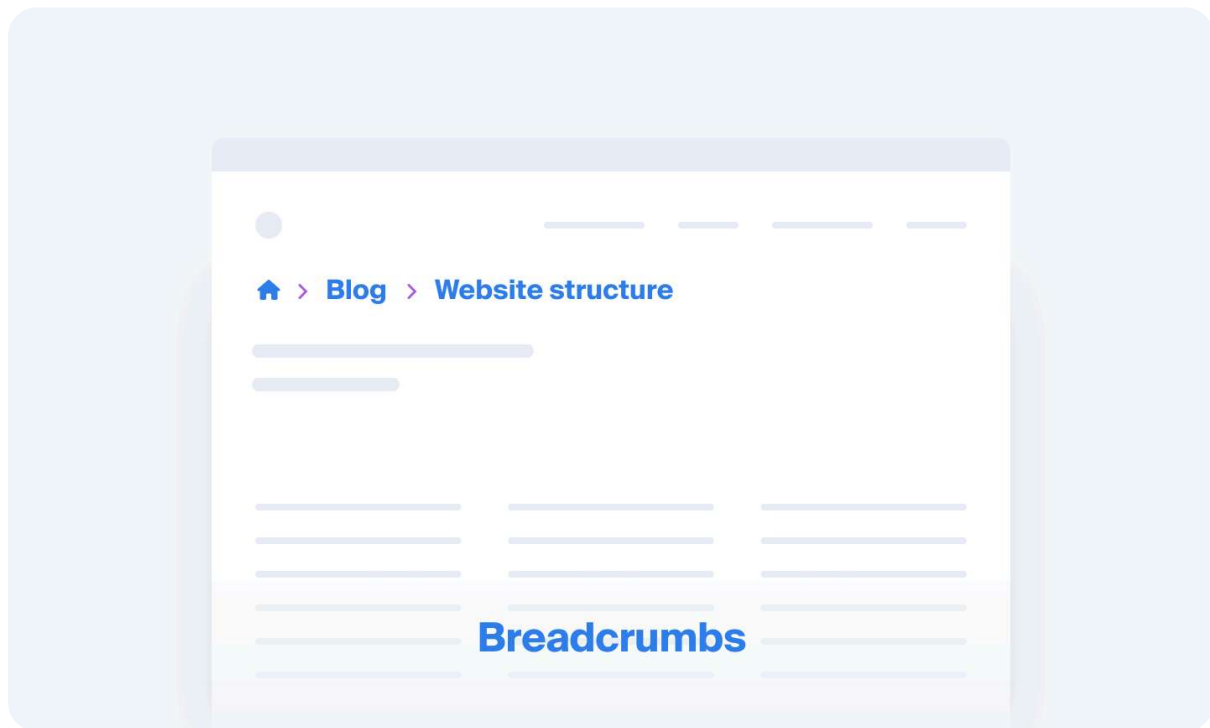
URL Structure

A clean, logical URL structure is essential for both users and search engines. Well-organized URLs are not only easier to read, but also help visitors quickly identify what content they're about to access. They create clear paths to information, and, from the search engines perspective, descriptive URLs improve crawling efficiency and click-through rates. A well-planned URL structure boosts both user experience and rankings - making your content more discoverable and clickable.

Breadcrumbs

Breadcrumbs are a navigation feature that shows users their current location within the website's hierarchy. Usually found at the top of pages, they provide a quick way for visitors to retrace their steps and navigate back to previous sections. This tool enhances usability by offering context to users, making it easier to navigate through deep or complex structures. Breadcrumbs are particularly powerful in hierarchical website

models, where deep levels of content benefit from this clear, easy-to-follow navigation aid.



Breadcrumbs show the current location, and can also serve as secondary navigation to go back.

Interlinking

Interlinking is the practice of connecting related pages within your website. By linking to other relevant content - whether it's articles, products, services, or case studies - you help users discover more of what your site has to offer, keeping them engaged longer. Beyond improving user experience, interlinking also strengthens SEO by distributing link equity across your pages, improving crawl efficiency, and helping search engines understand the relevance and relationships between content.

XML Sitemap

The XML sitemap is a behind-the-scenes SEO tool that ensures search engines can discover and index all the pages on your site. It acts as a

roadmap, guiding search engine crawlers to every page, even those that might be difficult to reach through regular navigation. While it doesn't impact user experience directly, it's an essential component making sure all content is properly indexed, which can lead to better visibility and higher rankings in search results.

Having XML sitemap not only ensures discoverability of the pages, but also makes indexing more efficient and quick.

How to Plan the Website Structure

Planning the website structure is rarely a one-size-fits-all option. It's a balancing act that requires you to weigh business goals, target audience, content needs, scalability, and maintenance strategies. Let's break it down.

Business Requirements

First, you must consider the core business objectives of your site. What role will it play? Is it informational, e-commerce, or corporate? Will it serve B2B, B2C, or another model? Complex business needs often point toward more advanced website structures than a simple linear one. But keep in mind, there's no universal answer. Flexibility and a thorough assessment of your needs are key.

For instance, if the goal is to inform potential clients and generate leads, a hierarchical structure might be the best choice. It lets you cover everything from company history and contact info to services and case studies - effectively guiding visitors through your value proposition. Or, if your next project is in large-scale e-commerce, then database-driven website structure is a clear choice.

Target Audience

Your target audience shapes the user journey you need to design. It's vital to anticipate all the different user roles that will visit your site and ensure they can easily find the information they're after. Webbed and hierarchical structures work well for sites serving multiple user roles, while linear and database-driven structures are more suited to sites with one or a few primary roles, each requiring a more streamlined flow or large volumes of dynamic content.

For example, if you have a single target audience - say, prospective clients looking for specific services - then a linear structure may work best. It will help direct users down a narrow, focused path, optimizing conversions and keeping the experience simple and goal-oriented. On other hand, if the target audience spectrum is broad, say, potential clients, investors, and media, a hierarchical website structure is a go-to option.

Content

The age-old adage "content is king" still rings true. A website's structure can only shine when it's aligned with the type and volume of content it houses. Linear and database-driven structures are ideal for simpler sites with one or a few content types. Linear is especially effective for small-scale content, providing a straightforward, focused user journey. On the flip side, hierarchical and webbed structures are better suited for websites that offer a variety of content types, allowing for more flexibility in navigating between them.

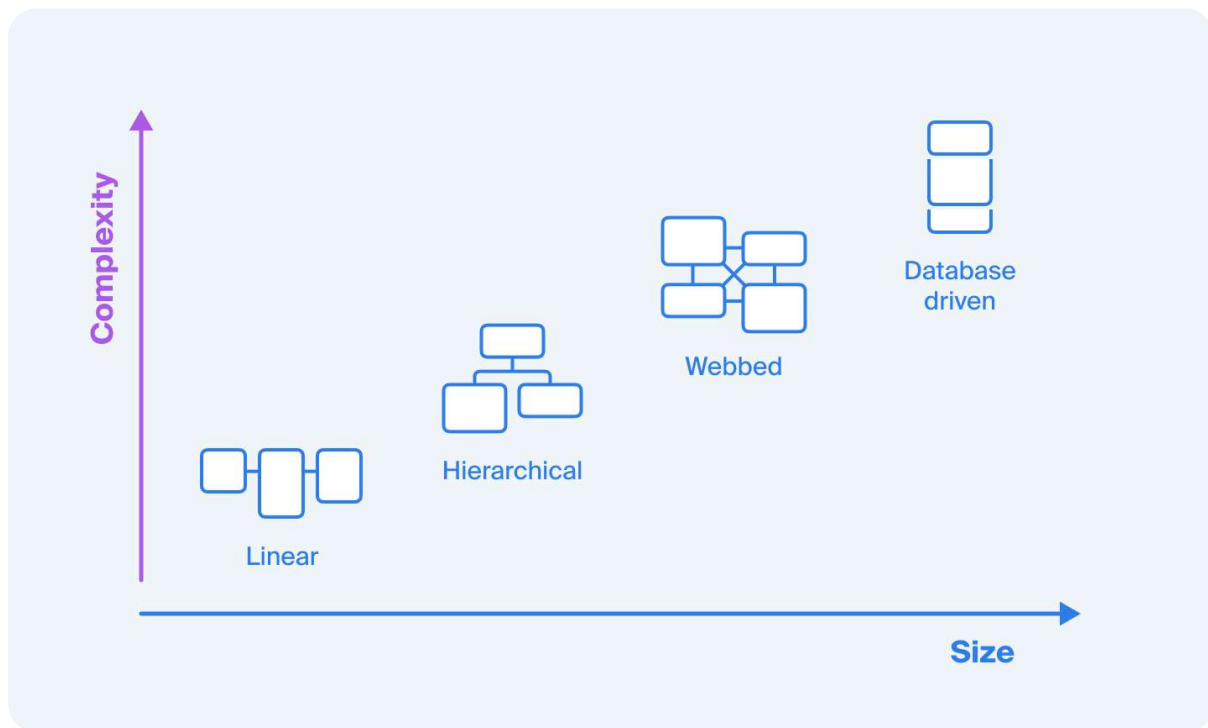
Maintenance & Scaling

Maintenance and scaling are two sides of the same coin: what you choose to build now will affect how easily it can evolve later. The simpler the structure, the easier it is to maintain. Think of it as keeping links between pages up to date - more links equal more maintenance work. However, scaling a linear structure into something more complex, like a

database-driven model, is practically impossible. In such cases, the best option might be to start fresh with a new website architecture.

Note that webbed and database-driven structures are more difficult to maintain, but they allow quick and relatively easy scaling.

To avoid future headaches, it's crucial to plan ahead. Carefully evaluate the long-term needs of your website, balancing maintenance ease with scalability. Choosing the right structure now can save you from the costly challenge of overhauling your site later.



Note that while this chart is true for average websites of a specific types, there can always be exceptions.

Common Website Structure Issues

A well-planned website structure is a powerful tool for user experience and journey. It ensures seamless navigation, maximizes engagement, and helps your site reach its full potential. However, structural issues can undermine your website's effectiveness, making it harder for users to find what they need and damaging your SEO efforts. Identifying and addressing these issues is essential to maintaining a site that performs at its best.

Poor Navigation & Unclear Hierarchy

Even the best content, products, or services can be overshadowed by poor navigation. If visitors can't find what they came for, they'll quickly bounce - no matter how great your offering is. A clear, intuitive navigation and well-defined hierarchy are crucial for keeping users on track. Without them, users may easily become disoriented and leave before reaching their destination.

To address this, start by evaluating competitors or similar websites. How many clicks does it take for users to find specific information or complete an action? You can also ask colleagues or friends to test the flow of your site, watching to see if they can easily navigate the structure. If you prefer data-driven insights, dig into your analytics to examine sources, session pages, and bounce rates. These metrics can help pinpoint where your navigation or hierarchy is falling short. For many, [visual representation](#) of a sitemap is best to work with, and helps to find problematic areas quickly.

Interlinking Problems

Interlinking is a fundamental aspect of web structure, playing a key role in both user engagement and search engine optimisation. Without relevant links connecting pages, users may struggle to discover related content, even if everything else on your site is functioning perfectly. Imagine Wikipedia without its contextual links or a product page without links to use cases and related blog posts - navigation would feel fragmented, and content would lose its context.

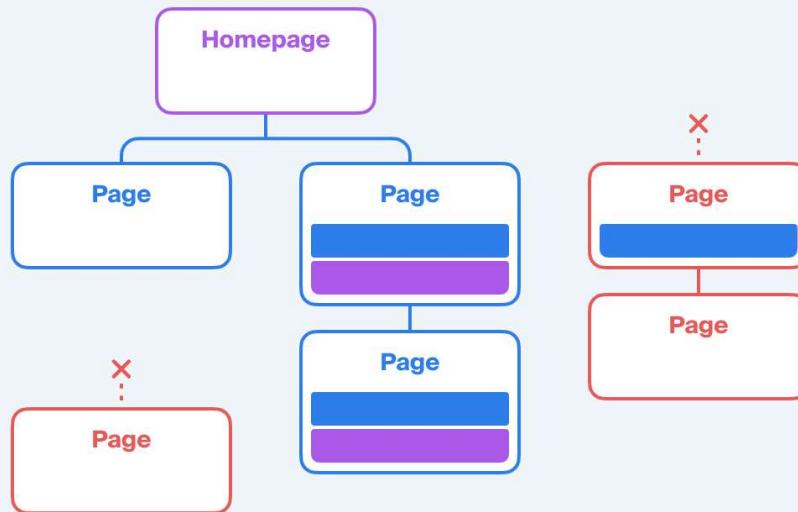
Linking pages generates link juice, the SEO value passed from one page to another.

To fix this, ensure your pages are well-connected with internal links. When adding links, focus on readability and avoid overloading any one page with too many links. Finding the right balance ensures that links enhance the user experience without distracting from the main content or overwhelming visitors.

Orphaned Pages

Orphaned pages are a silent SEO killer. These pages are not linked to any other content on your site, making them inaccessible through navigation, menus, or internal links. Essentially, they are stranded, only accessible via direct URL or external links. While search engines may find orphaned pages if they're included in your XML sitemap, they won't help your site's performance if they remain isolated.

To prevent orphaned pages from negatively impacting your website performance, conduct regular site audits. Once identified, either link them to relevant content or remove them entirely if they no longer serve a purpose.



Orphaned pages are not disconnected from the rest of the website, which makes them hardly, if not at all, discoverable,

Broken Links

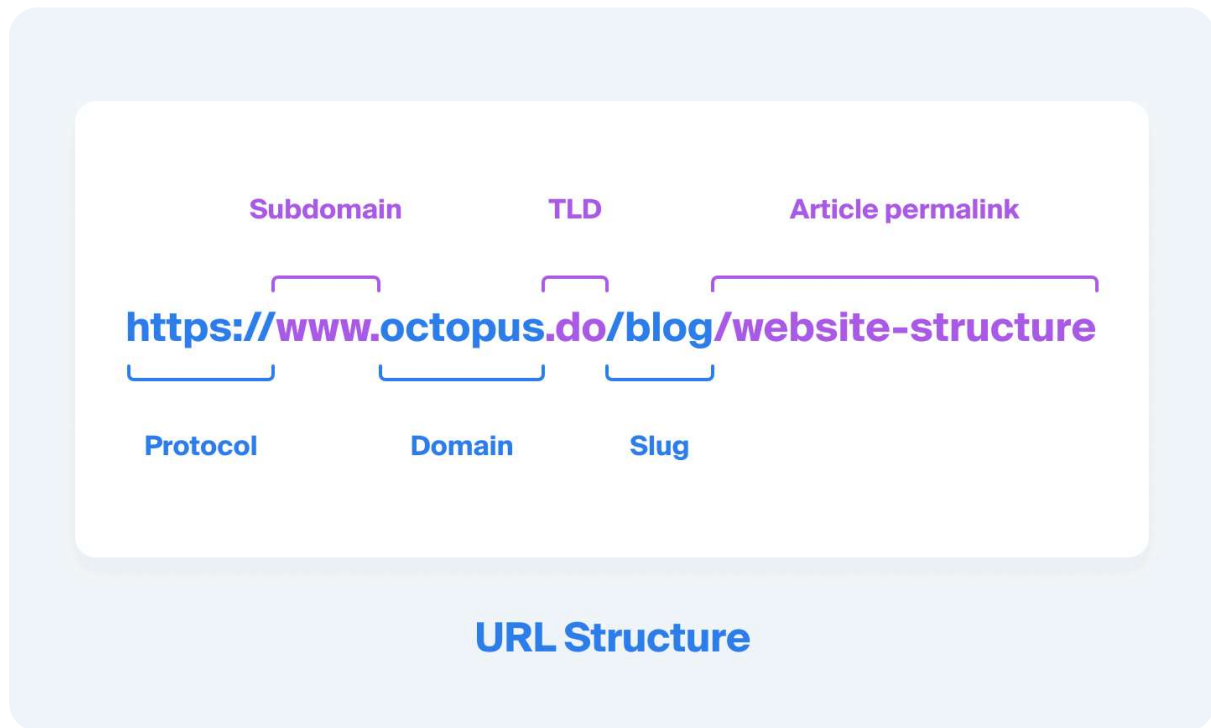
Broken links, often leading to 404 errors, are another structural issue that can substantially harm your site's user experience. These usually crop up after a redesign or from simple mistakes like typos. While they may seem minor, broken links send visitors on frustrating wild goose chases, reducing engagement and increasing bounce rates.

Fortunately, this issue is easy to address with crawling tools or website audit tools, which can quickly identify dead links. Fixing them is as simple as updating the link or redirecting users to the correct page.

Bad Taxonomy & Poor URL Structure

A well-organized taxonomy and logical URL structure are critical for website performance, both for users and search engines. Poor taxonomy - such as unclear or misleading naming of categories, subcategories, or sections can confuse visitors, making it harder for them to find the content they're seeking. Similarly, a poorly designed URL structure, where

links fail to reflect the hierarchy or logical organization of a website, can negatively affect user experience and search engine ranking.



While all URL contents are equally important, in this post I focus on slug and permalink parts.

Imagine reading an article with a title promising something entirely different from the content. That's how users feel when they navigate through unclear categories or subcategories. Misleading or inconsistent taxonomy disrupts the user journey and undermines trust. On the other hand, URLs that don't provide clear, descriptive paths to content confuse search engines and reduce ranking potential.



w.octopus.do/folder-24/page-000152



w.octopus.do/blog/website-structure



Two ways of building URL, where second is clearly better as it is clear and corresponds to the content.

To fix these issues, start by designing an intuitive taxonomy where category names truthfully represent the content within them. Simultaneously, create clean, SEO-friendly URLs that align with the site structure. Together, these elements ensure a smooth user experience and enhance discoverability for search engines.

No XML Sitemap

An up-to-date XML sitemap is an essential part of your website maintenance strategy. While many content management systems automatically generate and update sitemaps, countless websites still lack this crucial feature. Without a sitemap, search engines may fail to crawl all your pages or, worse, only index a few of them.

This is one of the easiest SEO issues to resolve - set up an automatic update to your sitemap whenever you add new pages or adjust the site structure. Regular updates ensure that search engines can find and index all your content efficiently. To create initial sitemap for your website, you can use [crawler services](#) that allow exporting to sitemap.xml file.

Unclear Information Architecture

Information architecture is the backbone of how content is organized and presented on your site. Think of it as the storytelling structure - you need a beginning, middle, and end. If your site's content feels disorganized or confusing, visitors may leave without fully engaging.

To keep users hooked, ensure your content flows logically, and always plan and review your website's structure in advance. Test your content with others to see if something is missing or out of place. A method like the [**content brick approach**](#) is a great tool for building solid information architecture and ensuring your site's message is clear and compelling.

Conclusion

Website structure is mainly led by the type of a website and business goals, which may create an idea that planning it isn't worth the effort - false. Always consider all aspects like target audience and user journeys, content, and future plans - it is better to confirm your assumption than create something and find out that a hybrid of database-drive and hierarchical structures was a better option.

Finally, consider implementing a recurrent website structure audit for monitoring for errors - your website is too good to lose visitors to these issues. Good luck!

[All articles](#)



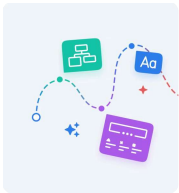
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